

Ancient Japan

Between the fourth and sixth centuries CE, Japan's many small territories were united into one country under an emperor. Japan's emperors said they were descended from the goddess of the sun. Japan used Chinese writing and began to follow Buddhism, which mixed with the local religion of Shinto.



Emperor Kanmu (ruled 781-806 CE)

Island state

Japan lies off the east coast of Asia. It is made up of four main islands: Honshu, Hokkaido, Shikoku, and Kyushu.



SCALE

0 50 miles
0 50 kilometers

God-like emperor

Japan has the world's oldest royal family. It has reigned for at least 1,500 years and continues up to the present day. The emperors were thought to be like gods, so only they could rule the country.



The native people of Hokkaido are called the Ainu.

Ainu people



Samurai warriors wore elaborate suits of armor.

Samurai armor

The Todai-ji Temple in Nara has a 49 ft (15 m) tall statue of the Buddha.

The Japanese traditional religion, Shinto, is based on the worship of spirits called kami.

Shinto shrine

Edo

Mount Fuji

Mount Fuji is a holy mountain, worshipped as a Shinto spirit.

Todai-ji buddha

Nara

Kyoto

Himeji

Kinkaku-ji

Himeji castle

Wealthy Japanese noblemen lived in castles, where they had their own followings of warriors called samurai. This castle in Himeji was originally built in the 1330s.

